

SAMPLE SYLLABUS: INTRODUCTION TO COMPARATIVE POLITICS

Daphne Yang

Course Description and Objectives

The primary objective of this course is to provide students with an introduction to key terms and concepts in the field of comparative politics. Some of the themes will include definitions of state formation, nationality, different forms of government, economic development, revolution, and immigration/migration. Students will leave this class with a comprehensive understanding of a number of political phenomena and the toolset to ask rigorous questions and make effective cross-system comparisons to answer them. The final exam will ask students to investigate a contemporary issue of their own choosing using the concepts that we will have learned throughout the course.

Course Format

This is an introductory course, consisting of lectures, exams, student discussions, and group activities/projects.

Course Structure and Assignments

Preparation for each class, as well as the final research paper are important for this course. The assignments and work requirements for the students are as follows:

(1) Class participation

10%

- Attend every session having all the assigned readings digested. You must be ready to fully engage in the class discussion.
- Repeated tardies or absence without legitimate excuse will negatively affect this grade.

(2) Midterm exam

30%

- Students will write an in-class exam based on the first half of the course, which covers an introduction to key concepts in comparative politics. Prior to the midterm, a list of theoretical concepts (“key terms”) will be given to students to review.
- The exam will consist of three short essay questions that ask students to present and synthesize the main arguments of the theoretical concepts, cite the relevant authors, and put them into conversation with each other.
- The exam will be conducted in-class, either handwritten or on a lockdown software. If accommodations are needed, please contact me with relevant details from the Office of Student Accessibility Services.

(3) In-class simulation

15%

- During one class session, the instructor will run a simulation of a real-world issue. Students will be split into groups that represent different countries or organizations, and the groups are expected to negotiate with each other to come to a reasonable resolution to the problem.
- The instructor will observe students during the simulation, and each student will be graded on the level of participation within their group discussions as well as between groups.
- Half of this grade (7%) will be accounted for in the ***Post-Simulation Reflection***, which is due a week after the simulation. In this report, students will be asked to reflect on the dynamics they observed during the simulation and how they could have improved their group's outcome, integrating class concepts into the reflection.

(4) Final Presentations 15%

- Each student will be asked to give an 6-8 minute presentation on their final research paper during the last few weeks of class.
- Students will be graded on the delivery/clarity of their oral presentation, the content/organization of the presentation itself, and the questions each student asks their peers during others' presentations.

(5) Final Research paper 30%

- Students can choose a question/topic that further explores an issue addressed in the course, a completely new one, or one that is inspired by the group projects as long as it is relevant to the course substantively/theoretically. The paper must be about 20 double-spaced pages (approximately 5,000 words, no more than 6,000). Any paper that does not follow these rules will be penalized, unless the instructor specifically gives you written permission.
- A paper proposal is due by Class Meeting 20. This proposal must include a research question, a working argument, theories/concepts that are relevant to this question, and a list of at least 10 scholarly sources that pertain to the topic. This proposal will not be graded but will receive extensive feedback from the instructor, and the degree to which the student incorporates the feedback into the final paper will be accounted for in the final grade.
- Students MUST schedule at least one office hour session before Class Meeting 20 to talk about their proposal with the instructor. Office hours after that can be scheduled at any time, but any proposal submitted without any office hours will be subject to grade deductions.

Course Schedule (based on a semester schedule, meeting twice a week)

The readings are presented in a strongly suggested reading order.

Note: Many of the readings draw from entries in the International Encyclopedia for Political Science (IEPS), available via the school library portal.

Class Meeting 1 Explanations of the course goals and syllabus

Class Meeting 2 What is political science?

Almond, G., & Genco, S. (1977). Clouds, Clocks, and the Study of Politics. *World Politics*, 29(4), 489–522.

Class Meeting 3 and 4 State formation

Andreas Osiander, “Westphalian Ideal State,” in International Encyclopedia of Political Science (IEPS).

Croxton, D., & Parker, G. (2008). “A swift and sure peace”: the Congress of Westphalia 1643–1648. In W. Murray & J. Lacey (Eds.), *The Making of Peace: Rulers, States, and the Aftermath of War* (pp. 70–99). chapter, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Grzymala-Busse, A. (2020). Beyond War and Contracts: The Medieval and Religious Roots of the European State. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 23, 19–36.

Class Meeting 5-8 Nation and nationalities

Anderson, B. R. (2016). *Imagined communities: Reflections on the origin and spread of nationalism* (Rev. ed.). Verso Books.

Class Meeting 9 and 10 Democracy

Mary Kaldor, “Democracy,” in Helmut K. Anheier and Mark Juergensmeyer, eds., *Encyclopedia of Global Studies* (not IEPS!) (7 pgs.)

Fukuyama, F. (2014). States and democracy. *Democratization*, 21(7), 1326–1340.

Adam Przeworski & Fernando Limongi, “Modernization: Theories and Facts,” *World Politics*, 1997

Collier, D., & Levitsky, S. (1997). Democracy with Adjectives: Conceptual Innovation in Comparative Research. *World Politics*, 49(3), 430–451.

Class Meeting 11 and 12 Non-democracies

Levitsky, S., & Way, L.A. (2002). Elections Without Democracy: The Rise of Competitive Authoritarianism. *Journal of Democracy* 13(2), 51-65.

- King, G., Pan, J., & Roberts, M.E. (2013). How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression. *American Political Science Review*, 107(2), 326–343. doi:10.1017/S0003055413000014
- Weiss Chen, J. (2013). Authoritarian Signaling, Mass Audiences, and Nationalist Protest in China. *International Organization*, 67(1), 1–35.
- Wu, W.-C. (2015). When do Dictators Decide to Liberalize Trade Regimes? Inequality and Trade Openness in Authoritarian Countries. *International Studies Quarterly*, 59, 790–801.

Class Meeting 13 and 14 Democratic Backsliding

- Norris, P., & Inglehart, R. (Eds.). (2019). The Cultural Backlash Theory. In *Cultural Backlash: Trump, Brexit, and Authoritarian Populism* (pp. 32–64). Cambridge University Press.
- Broz, L. J., Weymouth, S., & Frieden, J. (2021). Populism in Place: The Economic Geography of the Globalization Backlash. *International Organization*, 75, 464–494.
- Flaherty, T. M., & Rogowski, R. (2021). Rising Inequality As a Threat to the Liberal International Order. *International Organization*, 75, 495–523.

Class Meeting 15 MIDTERM REVIEW

Class Meeting 16 MIDTERM

Class Meeting 17 Special Module: Forming a good research question

Optional reading:

- Gustafsson, K., & Hagstrom, L. (2023). The insecurity of doing research and the ‘so what question’ in political science: How to develop more compelling research problems by facing anxiety. *European Political Science*, 15.

Class Meeting 18 and 19 The Political Economy of Development

D. Acemoglu and J. Robinson, *Why Nations Fail*, pp. 182-212, 302-334.

Johnson, C., *MITI and the Japanese Miracle* (Palo Alto: Stanford University Press, 1982), pp. 3-34, 83-115.

Chang, H.J., “Kicking Away the Ladder,” *Oxford Development Studies*, vol. 31, no. 1 (2010):

21-32

N. Grinberg, "From Miracle to Crisis and Back: The Political Economy of South Korean Long-Term Development," *Journal of Contemporary Asia*, 14 (2004): 711-634

Class Meeting 20 In-class Simulation

PAPER PROPOSAL DUE

Class Meeting 21 Revolutions

Sethi, J.D. (1977). "Mao and Gandhi: Convergence and Divergence," *China Report* Vol. 13, No. 1, pp. 16-33

Skocpol, T. (1982). "Rentier State and Shi'a Islam in the Iranian Revolution", *Theory and Society*.

Class Meeting 22 and 23 Politics of Violence

SIMULATION REPORT DUE

Hassner, R. (2003). To Halve and to Hold": Conflicts over Sacred Space and the Problem of Indivisibility. *Security Studies*, 12(4), 1–33.

Fearon, J. D., & Laitin, D. (2005). Ethnicity, Insurgency, and Civil War. *American Political Science Review*, 97(1), 75–90.

Dawkins, S. (2020). The Problem of the Missing Dead. *Journal of Peace Research*.

Menjívar, C. (2011). A Framework for Examining Violence. *In Enduring Violence: Ladina Women's Lives in Guatemala* (pp. 1–26). University of California Press.

Class Meeting 24 and 25 Globalization and Migration

Wallerstein, I. (1974). The Rise and Future Demise of The World Capitalist System: Concepts for Comparative Analysis. *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 16(4), 387–415.

Milner, H. (2021). Is Global Capitalism Compatible With Democracy: Inequality, Insecurity, and Interdependence. *International Studies Quarterly*, 00, 1–14.

Tichenor, D. (2001). *Dividing Lines: The Politics of Immigration Control in America*. Princeton University Press. Chapters 1 and 2.

Wimmer, A., Bonikowski, B., Crabtree, C., Fu, Z., Golder, M., & Tsutsui, K. (2025). Geo-Political Rivalry and Anti-Immigrant Sentiment: A Conjoint Experiment in 22 Countries. *American Political Science Review*, 119(2), 1018–1035.

Class Meeting 25 and 26 Final Paper Presentations